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THE GODDESS MYTH

HOW A VISION OF PERFECT MOTHERHOOD HURTS MOMS

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Motherhood Is Hard to Get Wrong. So Why Do So Many Moms Feel So Bad About Themselves?

Giving birth to her first child at home without medication was a foregone conclusion for Margaret Nichols. Pain would yield to will, and that would be that. Throughout her pregnancy, the 40-year-old New York City meditation teacher pored over the natural-birth canon, books like Ina May Gaskin's *Spiritual Midwifery* and *Bountiful, Beautiful, Blissful* by Gurmukh Kaur Khalsa. She became active in an international Facebook group dedicated to home and water births, stockpiling mindfulness tips to help her override the physical agonies of labor. She rented an inflatable blue birthing tub made of phthalate-free vinyl. Practically all her friends had given birth at home, and they assured her that the 118 gallons of water, warmed to roughly her body temperature, would function as "nature's epidural."

When Nichols went into labor last November, she felt elated, primed and cozy. She was surrounded by a midwife, a doula and her partner Jeff Hubbard. But 30 hours later she was in pain beyond imagination, howling what she later called desperate "animal-kingdom noises" as she hurtled in her midwife's car toward a local

hospital. There, she eagerly accepted anesthesia, took a brief nap and gave birth to a healthy son she named Bo.

Back home, Nichols commenced the course of exclusive breastfeeding that is prescribed to pretty much every new mother in America. She had hoped to nurse for two years. But after 5 months she developed lactation issues, which were exacerbated by a previously undiagnosed thyroid problem. She would have to supplement with donor milk and formula. Feeling like she hadn't "succeeded" and that her story wasn't "worthy," she went dark on Facebook.

The beginning of motherhood for Nichols was thus tainted by disappointment. Seven months later, she describes a kind of "mourning" that her biology wouldn't submit to her ideals. "I prepared so much for the birth, but the one thing that's not talked about as much is how much support we need, and how vulnerable we are afterward," she says.

You could argue that Nichols set herself up, that nobody should expect babies or bodies to adhere to best-laid plans. But like millions of other American moms, she had been bombarded by a powerful message: that she is built to build a human, that she will feel all the more empowered for doing so as nature supposedly intended and that the baby's future depends on it. Call it the Goddess Myth, spun with a little help from basically everyone–doctors, activists, other moms. It tells us that breast is best; that if there is a choice between a vaginal birth and major surgery, you should want to push; that your body is a temple and what you put in it should be holy; that sending your baby to the hospital nursery for a few hours after giving birth is a dereliction of duty. Oh, and that you will feel–and look–radiant.

The myth impacts all moms. Because they partly reflect our ideals, hospital and public-health policy are wrapped up with it. But even the best intentions can cause harm. The consequences vary in degree, from pervasive feelings of guilt to the rare and unbearable tragedy of a mother so intent on breastfeeding that she accidentally starves her infant to death.

A survey of 913 mothers commissioned by TIME and conducted by SurveyMonkey Audience found that half of all new mothers had experienced regret, shame, guilt or anger, mostly due to unexpected complications and lack of support. More than 70% felt pressured to do things a certain way. More than half said a natural birth was extremely or very important, yet 43% wound up needing drugs or

an epidural, and 22% had unplanned C-sections. Breastfeeding, too, proved a greater challenge than anticipated. Out of the 20% who planned to breastfeed for at least a year, fewer than half actually did. The majority of mothers in the survey, as well as those I talked to in dozens of additional interviews, pointed to "society in general" as the source of the pressure, followed by doctors and other mothers.

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Partly to blame are tsk-tsking furies: the barista who challenges your coffee order, the mother-in-law who asks why the ketchup isn't organic, the fellow partygoer who wonders, eyebrow cocked, if the drink you are holding is "virgin." "Anytime I pulled out a bottle and powdered formula, I felt eyes staring at me with daggers," says Ashley Sobel, a mom in New York. "Pumping instead of breastfeeding. Child going crazy on a plane. Going back to work immediately," says Janel Molton, who lives in Palo Alto, Calif. "We live in a world where people fling judgments with their fingertips."

This kind of mom-shaming, in which people feel licensed or even morally obligated to single out certain behaviors as wrong, might explain why many mothers I spoke to talked about their introductions to motherhood in the language of failure. A woman who had to be induced for a vaginal birth called her plans "not successful." A mom who had planned to go medication-free but ultimately "gave in" to an epidural said she wished she had "trusted" her body. And while only one mother I talked to had an elective C-section, the ones who had unplanned surgeries were almost uniformly disappointed. The feelings were similar and even more widespread among moms who either couldn't breastfeed or stopped for "selfish" reasons–bleeding nipples, lack of sleep, returning to work. Of course what these moms wanted–what we all know they wanted–was a healthy baby. That's what most of them

got. But what's lost in the cacophony of anxiety is the other thing every mom wants: to enjoy the beauty of motherhood.

How did we come to believe that mothers should be compliant with nature–the master of evolutionary hardball–and then feel responsible when it works against us? Certainly, some of it is the Internet, which increasingly delivers medical information with a side of personal opinion.

Google the basics and the top results will frequently lead to BabyCenter.com, part medical resource, part Reddit for parents. The site, owned by Johnson & Johnson, features articles written by a medical advisory board, but what more often turns up are links to its community forums, where the expert opinion is that of your fellow mother. Take the question "Should I breastfeed or bottle-feed?" Search sends you to a BabyCenter chat on which the top-rated answer–a ranking of "helpfulness" determined by users' likes–states: "For every 87 formula-fed babies who die of SIDS, only 3 breastfed babies die from SIDS." This is false. On the site's forums, you can find page after page of repeat visitors trash-talking and trolling one another. They call themselves "drama llamas." This is what passes for expertise on one of the web's most popular destinations for expectant and new mothers.

Elsewhere online, the goddess templates abound. There's Genevieve Howland, a.k.a. Mama Natural, whose YouTube series has more than 64 million views. Nearly 19 million people have watched the videos she posted of her two natural births. There was Beyoncé's pregnancy announcement on Instagram, showing the singer, then expecting twins, resplendent as a fecund deity. There are the legions of sublimely filtered public motherhoods, blogged in detail by women like Naomi Davis and Courtney Adamo.

It's a lot to live up to, even for them. And yet it seems only natural to revere the vision of the effortlessly fertile, happily pregnant DIY mama who finds affirmation in the excruciating. Who doesn't want to believe that motherhood is innate? I certainly did. When I was pregnant with my daughter, I Googled everything. I grilled my OB on skipping pain meds (she laughed) and pondered the benefits of a doula (she scoffed). I wound up having a C-section when my daughter didn't descend. And, yes, I was sad about it. My daughter couldn't nurse, so I pumped for almost five months, stashing away freezer bags with the zeal of a doomsday prepper to carry her to 6 months exclusively on breast milk. I felt smug about my supply, and guilty when I eventually stopped.

I asked Dr. Mary Jane Minkin, a clinical professor of obstetrics at Yale School of Medicine, if my feelings were common. She said she sees women making themselves "crazy" over the wish to do things as naturally as possible, including giving birth intervention-free and breastfeeding. "In the 1900s, we didn't have a lot of interventions," she tells me. "Guess what? People died. The average female life expectancy was 48. That was as 'natural' as it got." Catherine Monk, a psychologist and associate professor at Columbia University Medical Center, whose research focuses on maternal stress, echoes Minkin. "There's a crescendo of voices saying, 'If you don't do X or Y, you're doing it wrong,'" Monk says. The result is "a kind of over-preciousness about motherhood. It's obsessive, and it's amplified by the Internet and social media."

Time was, women desperately needed someone like Ina May Gaskin. The Tennessee midwife has authored several popular natural-birth manuals, starting with Spiritual Midwifery in 1975–not long after a time when husbands were often banned from delivery rooms, women were put under general anesthesia during labor and formula-feeding was the rule rather than the exception. The book detailed the methods of a freethinking commune called the Farm where Gaskin and other midwives delivered babies. (Women still give birth there.) Even for moms who didn't want to give birth in a cabin in the woods, Gaskin and those who followed her helped foster a culture in which women felt empowered to make their own obstetrical choices.

Gaskin's work also helped popularize the role of midwives in the U.S. Midwives, in turn, have precipitated the rise of the doula, or birth assistant, over the past few decades. In 2015, more than 38,000 births took place at home. Most of them were planned and part of a big increase in out-of-hospital births over the past decade, which now account for more than 1.5% of all U.S. births–almost as many as elective C-sections. Overall, C-sections are down for the third year in a row, making up 26% of low-risk first births.

Philosophies about having a baby the "right way"—and the scientific knowledge undergirding the advice we're expected to follow—are, like so much else in health trends, cyclical. To epidural or not to epidural? It will give you a wicked headache (highly possible, says science), or it will hamper your bonding with the baby (somewhat possible, says other science), or it may not work at all (there's always that chance). It wasn't long ago that formula was promoted as a bounty of women's lib. Today it's disparaged as a last resort.

These pendulum swings make motherhood harder and more confusing, something I heard a lot about from the moms I spoke with for this article. "With my first, I found myself really stressed out trying to live up to it all and embarrassed when I couldn't,"

says Seana Norvell, a California mom who had a C-section when her first baby was breech. She had trouble producing enough milk, but she obsessed about breastfeeding. Her husband and mother secretly fed her child formula, an act she says she is now grateful for. “As a new mom, it’s easy to feel judged,” says Tennessee mother Kaitlyn Kambestad. “There are so many conflicting studies, ideas and opinions. It’s overwhelming.”

The one thing being pitched universally these days is breastfeeding. There are good reasons to do it: it may help reduce gastrointestinal infections, middle-ear infections and some immune-based diseases like allergies and asthma. It’s free. It could be lovely bonding time with your baby. All of which is why more than 80% of American moms try it. Dr. Lori Feldman-Winter, a representative of the American Academy of Pediatrics, says evidence supports the belief that mother’s milk impacts babies’ brain activity. “It’s particularly apparent in premature babies,” she says. “Probably it’s most important in the most vulnerable populations.”

But where women used to claim that formula was excessively pushed on them, the preaching, both from many doctors and from fellow mothers, may now have gone too far the other way. Take the Baby-Friendly Hospital Initiative (BFHI). Established in 1991 by the World Health Organization and UNICEF, the BFHI is an effort

to help women around the world breastfeed exclusively from day one until a baby is 6 months old and for as long as possible once solid foods are introduced. It was meant to ensure proper nutrition, especially in regions that lack clean drinking water. But it has also been influential in the U.S. because it designates hospitals that conform to its rules as “baby-friendly.” Last year, almost 20% of America’s 3.9 million newborns were delivered in one of 420 BFHI-certified facilities. There’s at least one in every state.

If you walk into a BFHI-certified hospital, the signs will be clear: there are images everywhere of mothers nursing their babies. You won’t see any formula, bottles or pacifiers on display. Those are forbidden under BFHI guidelines, which state that human milk is “the normal way” to feed an infant. If a mother wants to formula-feed, this hospital must warn of “possible consequences” to the baby’s health. The BFHI also strongly recommends rooming-in, the practice of having babies sleep in the hospital room, if not in the bed, with their mom.

The pressure to room-in alarms some doctors. Last October, after several of Boston’s largest hospitals shut down newborn nurseries to achieve the BFHI designation, three prominent physicians wrote a scathing viewpoint in *JAMA Pediatrics*, a leading peer-reviewed journal. “There is now emerging evidence that full compliance with the 10 steps of the initiative may inadvertently be promoting potentially hazardous practices and/or having counterproductive outcomes,” wrote Dr. Joel L. Bass and Dr. Tina Gartley, both in pediatrics at Newton-Wellesley, and Dr. Ronald Kleinman, the physician-in-chief at MassGeneral Hospital for Children. They worry that rooming-in could lead to mothers’ accidentally smothering their children and possibly contribute to sudden unexpected postnatal collapse, a rare but often fatal respiratory failure.

When I ask Trish MacEnroe, the executive director of the BFHI’s U.S. arm, what the possible consequences of not breastfeeding are–

Injury? Illness? Death?–she tells me: “Breast milk and formula are not equivalent to one another. The mother’s breast milk is a unique biological food.” The goal of the BFHI, MacEnroe says, “is not to produce guilt, but it is to prevent regret. We believe mothers have the right to know about the impact of their decisions.”

Even if they don’t give birth in a BFHI-certified hospital, the refrain that new moms hear may not be so different. In April, the American Academy of Pediatrics issued a stern statement underscoring that “breastfeeding should be considered a public-health imperative and not merely a lifestyle choice.” But it’s hard to wrap your head around what “lifestyle choice” means when, say, you are suffering the pain of plugged ducts, or staying up all night for cluster feedings, or trying to please zealous lactation consultants. Not to mention the likelihood that you’re among the 87% of American workers who don’t have paid maternity leave. Given any–or all–of those factors, you could be forgiven for feeling like you’re set up to fail. As Rachel Zaslow, a certified nurse-midwife in Charlottesville, Va., puts it, “The minute a person becomes pregnant, there’s a notion that if you’re not doing those kinds of things, you’re not a good mother.”

Luckily, An anti-shame canon is growing. Political scientist Courtney Jung’s recent book *Lactivism* argues that breast milk has become an industry the way formula once was, compounding the incentives and pressures that potentially hurt moms. Dr. Amy Tuteur, a former OB, wrote *Push Back*, a polemic against natural parenting. In *Blaming Mothers*, legal scholar Linda Fentiman writes that “mothers—and pregnant women—are increasingly seen as exclusively responsible for all aspects of their children’s health and well-being.” In the spring, Dr. Alexandra Sacks wrote about the difficult process of matrescence—the total identity shift of becoming a mother—for the New York *Times*. All strains of the goddess myth.

There is a backlash beyond the bookshelf too. Last year, Dr. Christie Del Castillo-Hegyi, an emergency-room physician in Arkansas, founded Fed Is Best. The organization, run by a group of doctors, nurses and mothers, raises awareness of feeding options. It wants the BFHI to reconsider its stringent rules and to inform mothers on what Del Castillo-Hegyi says are under-recognized risks of exclusive breastfeeding, ranging from jaundice to starvation. She would know. Several years ago, in her quest to exclusively breastfeed, she nearly starved her infant son to death. Some of the mothers who work with Fed Is Best have had similar experiences, in a few cases leading to their babies' death. They are determined to keep such tragedy from striking others. "If you have leaders telling you this is what's best, it becomes ideology, policy, identity," says Del Castillo-Hegyi. "I can't even think of something more vulnerable than motherhood. And if motherhood means 'exclusive breastfeeding,' then a mother will do anything."

Mothers *will* do anything. I knew that going into my research for this story. But for all the communal aspects of bearing and raising children, for all the prescriptions we follow on the path of shaping another human, motherhood is a uniquely individual experience. Even amid harsh self-reflection, the moms I spoke to who had been let down ultimately concluded as much. "After the birth, I saw how judgmental I was about parenting styles," New York City mom Margaret Nichols says. "I realized we all have our path and way of thinking, and what works for each mother is exactly perfect for that child." Says Seana Norvell, who recently gave birth to her third child: "What I've learned is there are some things you can control, but there is a lot you can't. We just have to give ourselves a break and do the best we can."

It's hard to keep an individual "best" in mind amid images of glory and perfection, and anecdotal stories about what worked or didn't for another mom. But "women are coming out and talking more about [the problems of motherhood]," says Domino Kirke, a New

York doula with a practice in Los Angeles, whose popular Instagram account is filled with graphic but exhilarating images of the births she attends: mothers and their newborns amid bloody placenta on the bed at home as well as gracefully shot operating rooms where C-sections give way to joy. She says she wants to help mothers erase “the unknown,” which is where she thinks the shame and guilt come from.

Among the 112,693 photographs that are hashtagged #nationalbreastfeedingweek and #worldbreastfeedingweek, there are a few rogue bottles, some defiant pumps and the red, tear-streaked face of a mother named Angela Burzo. Her nursing selfie, captioned “This photo depicts my reality,” went viral in August, no doubt thanks to its truth-to-myth frankness. Even among the picture-perfect mommy bloggers, some are making a concerted effort to talk about the dissonance between what we see and what we feel. LaTonya Yvette, a popular lifestyle blogger who offers refreshing assessments of “honest motherhood,” is just one of them. Says Yvette: “The story I share as mother directly aligns with the mother I am.”

Motherhood in the connected era doesn’t have to be dominated by any myth. Social media can just as easily help celebrate our individual experience and create community through contrast. Moms have to stick together even as we walk our separate paths. We have to spot the templates and realize there are no templates. We have to talk about our failures and realize there are no failures.

—With reporting by ALICE PARK and ALEXANDRA SIFFERLIN/NEW YORK

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President Trump Sits on the Sidelines as Iraq Rolls Over the Kurds

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Holding Iraq together without the common enemy of ISIS looming over it was always going to be tough. President Donald Trump is not going to make the task any easier.

The rise of the Islamic State in 2014 forced many factions in Iraqi society to paper over their differences against a common enemy. In the contested areas of Iraqi Kurdistan, Kurdish authorities took control of oil-rich Kirkuk after the Iraqi army fled as ISIS advanced. On Oct. 16, Iraqi forces returned to take back Kirkuk and its surrounding areas by force, in response to Iraqi Kurds'

overwhelmingly voting for independence in an unsanctioned referendum on Sept. 25.

The Iraqi Kurds might feel hard done by. For the past three years their peshmerga fighters, trained and armed by the U.S., have played a pivotal role in beating back ISIS. Their expectation was that in time, they would be rewarded with a homeland of their own, despite the strenuous objections from neighboring Turkey, Syria and Iran, all of whom have sizable Kurdish populations of their own.

The Kurds' insistence on carrying out a referendum, while understandable, put the U.S. in a bind. Washington opposed the vote for fear it would weaken pro-U.S. Iraqi Prime Minister Haider al-Abadi ahead of elections next year. The U.S. has spent over a decade trying to stabilize the country it invaded in 2003, propping up the central government while also providing aid to Kurdish forces. Hence Trump's announcement on Oct. 16 that "we're not taking sides."

While the rhetoric makes sense, Trump's decision to decertify Iran's compliance with the nuclear deal, coupled with his inconstant support for Iraq's Kurds, have pushed things closer toward an endgame. In recapturing Kirkuk, Iraqi security forces were joined by Shi'ite militias backed by Iran. The Iranians, emboldened by Trump's nuclear-deal gambit, have every incentive to push the U.S. into these kinds of existential geopolitical dilemmas.

To be fair to Trump, this is not the first time a U.S. President has had to give way to realities on the ground. Obama did virtually the same with the Ukrainians when Vladimir Putin invaded in 2014, leaving Kiev in the lurch. The difference here is that it was Trump's unilateral decision to provoke Iran that ended up forcing moves in Iraq, much like it was Trump's unilateral backing of Saudi Arabia that touched off this year's spat between Qatar and other Gulf

monarchies. With allies like these, Iraq’s Kurds might be asking if they really need enemies.

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Amid Tragedy in California's Wine Country, There's Some Cause for Hope

On Sunday, Oct. 8, I was having dinner at the winery Ovid in Napa Valley with Jack Bittner and his wife Sara. It was a sort-of-business, sort-of-social get-together that's characteristic of a life in wine: Jack runs the place, and I write about wine. The night was perfect–early October, harvest, the best time to be in Napa. But it was strangely windy.

Around 9, Sara took their daughter down the hill to their home in St. Helena while Jack and I stayed to talk. The wind moaned and shuddered, an eerie Halloween gale that seemed about three weeks too early. At some point I said something like, "That wind is nuts." We chatted a bit longer and then called it a night, because he had to be back at work at 4 a.m. to pick the last of their petit verdot. At least that was the plan.

Over the next few hours seven wildfires broke out in Northern California's wine region. The "Diablo winds," blowing 70 m.p.h. at times, spread the flames with terrifying speed. Add to that already high temperatures, humidity in the single digits and a wet winter

that had produced abundant growth in the forested hills, and you had the perfect conditions for a disaster.

As of Oct. 18 the fires have burned across more than 210,000 acres, hitting Napa, Sonoma, Solano and Mendocino counties particularly hard. More than 5,700 homes and businesses have been destroyed, and over 40 people have died, a grim toll that is sure to rise. About 60 people remain missing. It is the most destructive fire here in decades.

The flames aren't quenched yet, but they aren't growing. The lethal Tubbs fire, which tore through densely populated neighborhoods in Santa Rosa, is now more than 90% contained. The massive Atlas fire, on the eastern side of Napa Valley, is 83% contained. Evacuation orders, at one point affecting about 100,000 people, are being lifted. The firefighters, numbering more than 10,000, some from as far away as Australia, are slowly winning.

A couple of days ago I stood with Ray Signorello next to the ruins of his winery on the Silverado Trail in Napa. The last time I was there, a few years ago, he told me about the chef they had just hired and the culinary program he hoped to ramp up for visitors to the winery. "I guess we'll take that on the road for a bit," he now says.

The winery, Signorello says, had burned straight up, like one of those chimneys used for lighting coals in a backyard grill. As he considered the scorched brick and twisted metal in front of us, Signorello says, "As bad as this is, it could have been worse. My wife was there that night–she called me to say there was fire on the ridge behind us and she was getting out. Which she did."

Wineries make up only a small percentage of what's been lost. Whole neighborhoods in Santa Rosa burned. Karissa Kruse, president of Sonoma County Winegrowers, lived in one of them, Fountaingrove. She recalls a neighbor pounding on her door at 2:30 a.m. "The streets were just chaos," Kruse says. "You looked up in

the hills and saw a wall of orange coming. I got a flashlight, got on some clothes, grabbed the cats, grabbed my computer … I was out of there in 18 minutes.” Kruse’s house burned to the ground.

The story of these fires is tragic for many people, and it is still being written. But there are reasons to be optimistic. Vineyards, as it turns out, don’t burn well. In fact, at this time of year, with green leaves still on the vines and trunks full of moisture, they act as effective firebreaks (one reason the damage to wineries was far less than what one might expect). For another, despite the expectations created by images of hillsides ablaze and torched buildings, the 2017 vintage here will most likely be unaffected. Close to 85% of the grapes had already been harvested before the fires started; more in some areas, less in others. The omnipresent smoke may affect the flavors of fruit left on the vine, but the juice already fermenting in tanks and barrels should be fine. And vast portions of the region were untouched by the flames; Napa and Sonoma counties together form an area about twice the size of Rhode Island.

When I finally reached Jack Bittner, I learned he had spent several hours that Sunday fighting fires at his in-laws’ house near Calistoga. “Miraculously, it’s still there … though it’s a charred moonscape in all directions,” he says. Then he went back up to Ovid and, like vintners all over Napa and Sonoma, fires be damned, got the last ton of grapes in.

Isle is the executive wine editor of Food & Wine

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Why You Shouldn’t Punish Your Kids for Lying

Kazdin is Sterling Professor of Psychology and Child Psychiatry at Yale University and director of the Yale Parenting Center; he is a former President of the American Psychological Association and teaches a course open to the public on Coursera: Everyday Parenting: The ABCs of Child Rearing.

Getting your children to stop lying is challenging. There are many influences (TV, movies, video games and some great books) in which lies are common. Children see parents lie to others, if only to be polite. Most parents add to that with tales about the lives and activities of Santa Claus or the Tooth Fairy, or to allay fears. (“This will not hurt!”) Parents do this out of love, but for some children, lying can become a problem.

The most common reactions to children who lie are explaining why it is wrong and punishment. As ways of changing behavior, these are ineffective. Here are three better tools supported by research to use instead.

Praise: You could ask your child to say something that happened at school that is true. It is not critical what that is. This is about practice. When your child complies, praise him enthusiastically. Be specific: “That was great! You told me what happened just like I asked. Wow!” and give your child a hug or a high five. If your child says something true in the course of her day, praise that behavior too. Aim for one or two interactions like this a day. If you happen to “catch” your child in a lie, be matter-of-fact in your disapproval. Say something like, “That is not true and could get you in trouble outside of the home; it is better to say the truth.”

Model: Explicitly tell the truth. This could be about something that happened when you were a child or something that happened during the day. It need not be dramatic. Another option is to play a game at dinner. Each person tells one thing that was true that day. Again, give a little praise to the child who normally lies if she plays along.

[video id=F0cp1vwC]

De-emphasize punishment and moralizing: They are unlikely to change behavior or develop the conduct you want. That does not mean ignoring, lying or letting it go. Rather, use very mild punishment (light reprimand, short loss of privilege, a brief time-out). More severe, harsh or enduring punishments (shouting, taking away something for a week, hitting) are not more effective in actually changing the frequency of lying.

Try these procedures for two to three weeks and see where you are. Usually they can be dropped by then. It is unlikely that lying will be completely eliminated, but with the right encouragement, it can be dramatically lessened.

Kazdin is the director of the Yale Parenting Center

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When Men See Other Men Behaving Badly

Susanna Schrobsdorff writes the *It's Not Just You* newsletter on Substack

A lot of men are asking themselves if they have ever done something that a woman somewhere is tweeting about with the #MeToo hashtag in response to the question, Have you ever been harassed or assaulted? It all began with the horrific accusations against producer Harvey Weinstein over the past month. Since then, the ugliness has swamped our consciousness. It seems to be everywhere, like rot in the walls. Women are walking around feeling less alone, yet they are scared and sickened by the magnitude of the problem. How will we move forward?

The hope is that this catharsis will prompt men and institutions to acknowledge and change their behavior when it comes to the harassment of anyone. I'm sure that some men recognize their own behavior in those tweets. Maybe they're ashamed of their actions or their complicity. Maybe they have learned something about what women go through. Of course, there are those deeply narcissistic, powerful men like Weinstein who can't imagine that a woman

doesn’t want them. Or they don’t care because they’ve gotten used to a life where no one says no without swift and cruel retaliation. (Hell hath no fury like a rejected bully.)

But a lot of men really aren’t sure if they’ve crossed a line. Male friends tell me they’ve been sifting through memories, thinking, I’m no monster like Weinstein, but what about that time I complimented a woman on her hair–was that creepy?

To answer that question, women are posting lists of things men shouldn’t do or say. They advise men to think of women as … people. Or that if men are distracted by a woman’s womanness, they should just think of her as the Rock, as Anne Victoria Clark wrote. Another list, “57 Things I Need You to Stop Doing to the Women You Work With,” includes not commenting on a woman’s appearance, ever, and not grabbing her butt.

But here’s the problem: we are lumping sexual assault in with “I like your jacket.” Part of being treated like a person at work is being treated as a friend, perhaps for a lifetime. And friends talk about their lives outside of work, their kids or their cancer treatment, because we are human first. There’s no fixed line between friendship and creepy. And what about the many people who date, marry and break up with colleagues? Then the line between icky and romantic gets really blurry. Think of John Cusack’s character standing outside his ex’s bedroom with a boom box in the movie Say Anything. Read one way, it’s the start of a marriage; in another way, he’s a stalker. We’ve been raised on romances in which the guy “just wouldn’t give up until she said yes,” that she would go out with him or marry him.

Clearly, we have a lot of cultural baggage. So as helpful as a list of don’ts might be, it’s not enough. I think men need to hear it from women directly. Is it possible for men to ask women if they’ve done something to make them uncomfortable or scared? And if they did, would we answer no when we meant yes so as not to

offend? I’m not sure. But maybe more honesty is something we can salvage from this awful swamp. It’d be a start anyway.

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Megyn Kelly: Now We Need Men as Our Allies

Kelly hosts Megyn Kelly Today *on NBC at 9 a.m.*

When the Roger Ailes sexual-harassment scandal broke in July 2016 and he was forced out of Fox News in disgrace, I thought we might be at the beginning of a sea change. When Silicon Valley began erupting with similar stories this past spring, I thought, Yes, here we go. Now that we are in the midst of the Harvey Weinstein scandal, many are proclaiming, “This is it. It ends now.” My take? Maybe. But we have a lot of work to do.

First and foremost, the victim blaming must stop. Often it seems there is almost a presumption that those who get harassed must have done something to invite it, which leads too many victims to stay silent. Actress Mayim Bialik thought this was the time to discuss the virtues of “not being a perfect ten” or being someone who hasn’t had plastic surgery or who avoids flirting with men. (She apologized.) Donna Karan also had to apologize for suggesting that women are “asking for it.” How insulting to

victims. There are laws in this country. Wearing a short skirt doesn't violate them. Shoving one's tongue down an employee's throat does.

Second, let's get real about the options that harassment victims face. "Report it!" we say. "You have rights!" Easy to say; much harder to do. The thing that keeps harassment targets quiet, in my view, is not that they do not know their options. It's that they know their options stink.

Go to HR? HR may have to tell the harasser — and he may survive the bout. "He cannot legally retaliate," people tell us. We know. But we also know the practical realities of starting wars with powerful men. So most women stay quiet. And then if they do find the courage to come forward, the first thing they're asked is, "Did you report it?" (In my case, I did tell a supervisor that Ailes had harassed me. Nothing was done.)

More women speaking up is huge. But more women in power — at or near the top of companies or industries — is equally important. What women need is someone they feel safe approaching. An outside lawyer whose paycheck is not dependent on the boss, perhaps — Fox News now has such a person. But women will still be reluctant unless they believe this person isn't loyal to the company first.

Perhaps the most critical solution lies in partnership with the men. The harassers must stop; we know this. But male titans of industry must stand up for decency. Shout it from the rooftops and whisper it in the bars when women aren't around, because we don't often get invited to the late-night drinks where those conversations happen. Those are the moments. Women alone cannot change the culture. We need men. Evolved ones. Kind ones. Brave and scared ones, like those who fear expulsion from the fraternity if they object to a male colleague's bad behavior.

All of this is easier in an environment in which the law and one's principles are vigorously enforced, even and especially when no one is looking. In other words, it's not women vs. men; it's ethical vs. not. Which side are you on?

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Roy Moore Is Rising in Alabama. Here's How He Could Disrupt Trump's GOP

Philip Elliott is a senior correspondent at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau, where he covers national campaigns, elections, and government. He also writes TIME's politics newsletter, The D.C. Brief.

Roy Moore has been talking with God. It's a brilliant October afternoon in downtown Montgomery, Ala., and inside the weathered brick home serving as the headquarters for Moore's Senate campaign, the twice-removed former chief justice of the Alabama supreme court leans back in his chair and shares what the Lord has told him.

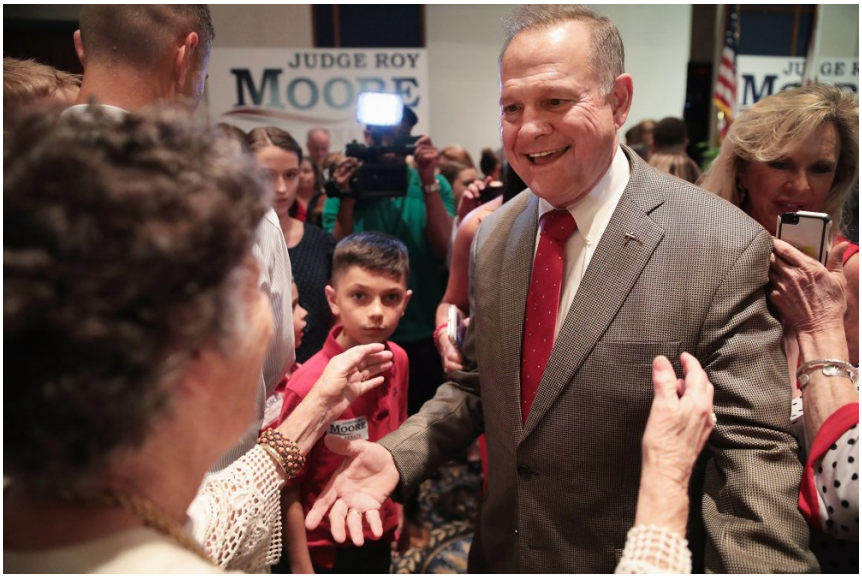
"Our rights come from God," the 70-year-old Baptist says. "The Constitution was founded upon God. It was made for moral and religious people. It is the fallen nature of man that the Constitution meant to restrain."

Moore is favored to win the Dec. 12 election to fill the Senate seat that was vacated when Jeff Sessions stepped down to become the

nation's Attorney General. And while several conservative rabble-rousers have joined the Senate in recent years–both Rand Paul of Kentucky and Ted Cruz of Texas come to mind–there is nobody in Washington quite like Moore: a judge who recites anti-abortion poetry, rejects the theory of evolution, doesn't think Muslims should be allowed to serve in Congress, fought to keep antiquated wording in the Alabama constitution requiring school segregation and suggested the Sept. 11 terrorist attacks were God's punishment for America's sins. His first priority in the Senate, he says, will be to fight to impeach the five Supreme Court Justices who voted in 2015 to give same-sex couples the right to wed from coast to coast. (Such a move would make history: the last attempt to remove a Supreme Court Justice began in 1804, and proved a failure.)

Moore is not only a culture warrior. He is a populist Christian and a soldier in the larger Republican revolution that is rooted in frustration with Washington and prizes anti-establishment anger over all else. The same uprising that carried President Donald Trump into the White House looks poised to deliver an even more disruptive figure, one the party cannot control.

And the revolution is about to spread well beyond Dixie. Its field general, former Trump strategist Stephen Bannon, says he is recruiting a slate of insurgent outsiders who will vow to topple the Republican ruling class. "Right now it's a season of war against the GOP establishment," Bannon told a gathering in Washington on Oct. 14. Three days later, Bannon showed up in Arizona to endorse the right-wing Senate candidate Kelli Ward, who is running against incumbent Republican Jeff Flake, a Trump critic. Bannon's allies say they plan to challenge sitting Republican Senators in Nevada, Mississippi, Montana, Wisconsin and West Virginia. "The anger we all saw bubble up in 2010 is even more pronounced now," says Andy Surabian, a top Bannon lieutenant. "Every Republican who hasn't lived up to their promises should be watching their backs."



At a moment when the party should be capitalizing on unified control of Washington, the 2018 elections are shaping up instead as perhaps the nastiest GOP civil war in a generation. A collection of outside groups tied to Senate majority leader Mitch McConnell has already raised more than $40 million this fall to protect incumbents next year from Bannon's insurgents, and donors are preparing to quadruple that if needed. At stake is whether the GOP remains a party of traditional conservative principles, or becomes something else entirely. Senator John McCain warned in an Oct. 16 speech his party risks following "some half-baked, spurious nationalism cooked up by people who would rather find scapegoats than solve problems."

Gallant, Ala., pop. 742, is a quiet village in the foggy upstate hills, with a volunteer fire department, a post office and the town's First Baptist Church. This is where Moore worships. "He's a straight-shooter and a man of God," deacon Arnold Gray says at an Oct. 15 prayer meeting. Faith has long been Moore's foundation. The judge and his wife Kayla, who have been married for 32 years, live on a 50-acre property, protected by a locked gate, in a hillside house you can't see from the wooded road. The Ten Commandments are posted above their bed. Moore, who doesn't touch whiskey or beer, wears a 10-gallon hat and speaks extemporaneously–"I'm not a speechwriter," he says–sometimes pausing to grin with his tongue

between his teeth. He can recite whole passages of works that move him, from Blackstone's Commentaries to the Federalist papers to his own poetry, which ranges from decrying "babies piled in dumpsters" to comparing love to butterflies.

Moore spent his formative years in Gallant, the oldest of five children born to a jackhammer operator and a homemaker. He was a studious child. "I never got any trouble out of that boy–he's always loved going to church," says his mother Evelyn Ridgeway. "He never went outside. I'd find him studying in his room at 3 in the morning. Kids used to make fun of him." But Moore was willing to go his own way. He "prayed hard" to get into West Point, where he says his fellow cadets had little patience for "a Southern boy with a strong adherence to what I believed." After a stint as a military police commander in Vietnam, he studied law at the University of Alabama and settled back in his home county. He made a reputation as a tough prosecutor. "I lost maybe four cases in five years, and I tried hundreds," he says. After losing an election for a local judgeship, he spent a year working as a rancher in rural Australia. In 1992, he was appointed to preside over the 16th circuit court of Alabama after the sitting judge died.

Then came the move that put him on the map. "I'd prayed not to get appointed unless it was God's will," Moore recalls as he

prepares to drive from his campaign headquarters to meet Kayla across town. “I got appointed. I had to start decorating my courtroom, and I figured I’d hang a big picture of Washington or Jefferson, but I couldn’t find any. So I pulled out a little plaque of the Ten Commandments that I’d made in 1980.” The American Civil Liberties Union sued, but Moore refused to budge. “I said ‘What, I can’t acknowledge God’s role in this?’”

In 2000, Moore was elected the chief justice of the Alabama supreme court. He soon commissioned a granite monument to the Ten Commandments–the “moral foundation of the Constitution,” he maintains–to sit in the rotunda of the courthouse. It weighed 5,280 lb. and drew nearly as many protesters. A legal controversy erupted, and in November 2003 the Alabama court of the judiciary removed Moore from office when he refused to ditch the monument. It made him a national celebrity among evangelicals. Moore took the reins of the Foundation for Moral Law, the judiciary-action group he founded in 2002 that fights for public prayer and against abortion and same-sex marriage. In 2012, he ran again for chief justice and won. Four years later, he was removed from the post by judicial officials once again–this time for telling Alabama judges not to issue marriage licenses to same-sex couples, in defiance of the U.S. Supreme Court. “The ultimate goal of the movement is to drive the nation into a wasteland of sexual anarchy that consumes all moral values,” he wrote in an opinion on Obergefell v. Hodges, the Supreme Court case that he describes as a “sudden overthrow of our government.”

Says Moore: “I don’t hate people because they profess homosexuality. I hate sin. And sodomy has historically been an aberration of our laws.”

This isn’t the kind of talk you hear much anymore in Senate hallways. But then, Alabama is a deeply red state that has elected Senators like Sessions and, in the 1980s, Jeremiah Denton, who believed the U.S. was being destroyed by moral decay. When

Sessions was nominated to become U.S. Attorney General, Alabama's Republican governor, Robert Bentley, chose state attorney general Luther Strange to fill Sessions' old seat until a special election could be held. At the time, Bentley was under state investigation on allegations that he had used taxpayer dollars to conceal an extramarital affair with a female staffer. Voters speculated that Bentley had sent Strange to the Senate so the governor would have a chance to pick a more favorable prosecutor. Bentley resigned. The suspicion hurt Strange. Says local conservative activist John Pudner: "Alabama doesn't like insiders."

Both Trump and McConnell backed Strange, but Bannon cast his lot with Moore, who was leading in the polls when Bannon touched down in September to endorse him in the closing days of the state's GOP primary. "His team was up three touchdowns with 45 seconds left, and he found the first plane so he could be on the sidelines when the clock hit zero," a veteran Republican strategist says of Bannon. Moore went on to beat Strange, capturing 54.6% of the vote. Moore downplays his ties to the Breitbart boss. "I met Steve Bannon when the primary was about toward the end of it," the candidate recalls. "I talked to him on the phone and he offered his support. I said, 'Well, fine, I'd love to have your support.'" Moore also professed surprise when Trump announced on Oct. 16 that he would be meeting with Moore the following week. "Well, that's the first I'm hearing about it," Moore chuckled several hours later. "But let's make it happen."

The Bible-quoting jurist and real estate mogul turned President may not have much in common. But their interests may align: a year after Trump's election, mainstream Republicans still run things on Capitol Hill–and things still aren't getting done. Multiple attempts to repeal and replace Obamacare have failed. The promised border wall is scarcely closer to reality. Tax reform is struggling to get off the ground, and a government shutdown looms on the horizon. "We have a slew of politicians that care more about

their power than they do about doing what's right for this country," says Ed Henry, a Republican in Alabama's house of representatives and a Moore backer. "That's why Americans voted for Donald Trump, and that's why Alabamians are voting for Roy Moore. They want to upset the apple cart."

Bannon and his allies want to capitalize on this frustration. Their strategy is to knit together a disparate coalition, from evangelical populists to small-government libertarians, to take on the proverbial swamp. Already Bannon is jetting around the U.S., meeting with major Republican donors in a bid to convince them to defect from McConnell's team. Along the way, he is advising would-be recruits on how to savage incumbents. Republicans are defending eight Senate seats in 2018, many of them in red states that are fertile ground for an upset. Only Cruz–a favorite of the wealthy Republican donors Robert and Rebekah Mercer, who have also bankrolled Bannon–appears safe from a primary threat. "The grassroots saw they can be successful with President Trump," says Surabian, Bannon's ally, "and they now see they can be successful in dislodging Mitch McConnell as majority leader and replacing squishy, weak-kneed Republicans with anti-establishment, America First–styled Republicans."

One question Bannon has yet to answer is whether he can match McConnell's cash. During the past two election cycles, establishment Republicans have trounced Tea Party–style insurgents in a sweep of competitive primaries. McConnell's aides understand the stakes. The GOP leader tried to make sure the President understood them when they met privately on Oct. 16, after which the two Republican leaders took questions together in the White House Rose Garden in a forced show of unity. "You have to nominate people who can actually win, because winners make policy and losers go home," McConnell told reporters, citing failed candidates like Christine O'Donnell, Sharron Angle, Todd Akin and Richard Mourdock, Tea Party–backed nominees who squandered winnable races.

Democrats insist that Moore could fall into the same category. His opponent in December will be Doug Jones, a 63-year-old former U.S. Attorney who made his name prosecuting the perpetrators of the 1963 Ku Klux Klan bombing of a Birmingham church that killed four African-American girls. That's as strong a profile as a Democrat in Alabama is ever likely to get, but the odds are long. Trump won nearly two of every three votes in this state in 2016; no Democrat has been elected to the Senate from Alabama since Howell Heflin in 1990.

Republicans worry about Moore too; only a small fraction of the House Republican conference and even fewer of his Senate colleagues have endorsed his candidacy. Around Washington, GOP strategists have taken to joking about how Moore makes Senate hard-liners like Cruz, who sparked a government shutdown in 2013, look tame. Some fear that as the party pushes for a tax-cut package, Moore's strong cultural views could present a distraction. In his interview with TIME, the judge remarked that NFL players who knelt during the national anthem in protest against police brutality or systemic racism were committing a crime. "It's against the law, you know that?" Moore said. "It was an act of Congress

that every man stand and put their hand over their heart. That's the law." (Moore was referring to a section of the U.S. code that outlines how people should conduct themselves when the anthem is played, but the code merely outlines proper etiquette; there are no legal penalties.)

If Moore loses in December, it would shave the party's cushion in the upper chamber to a single vote–which means there is an outside chance that Moore's rise and Bannon's crusade could cost the party control of the Senate, giving Democrats the numbers, and the subpoena power, to thwart every aspect of Trump's agenda. And in the much more likely event that Moore wins, the Senate is about to become harder to govern–if that's possible. "Electing Moore would be like throwing a bomb into the Senate," Jones says over coffee at a diner in the town of Moulton on Oct. 16. "He can't work with anybody. People here don't want to go backward, and some of his divisive and extreme rhetoric takes us back decades."

None of this concerns Moore. Late on a Monday afternoon in October, he was sitting in the parlor turned conference room of the house that serves as his campaign office. The light was fading from the windows. Moore was about to drive over to the offices of the Foundation for Moral Law, which his wife Kayla now runs. The high-ceilinged offices in the historic Montgomery building still has five plaques of the Ten Commandments on its walls, and the judge keeps an office there where he plots his next battle. "You think the people of Alabama don't understand what I believe?" he says. "It's God's providence that we've won, because it's inexplicable in modern terms. There's all this consternation in Washington over 'What does this mean?' It means the country is waking up to the relevance of God."

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When You’re Pregnant, Everyone Is Suddenly an ‘Expert’ on Your Health

Siobhan O'Connor is editorial director, health, at TIME Magazine and Time.com, and is co-author of the *No More Dirty Looks*, a book about the cosmetics industry and natural beauty. She lives in Brooklyn.

For 30-odd weeks, my barista and I have had roughly the same routine. I order my morning coffee and he pretends he hasn’t heard me, filling in the blank with a joke. “Mocha double-shot no-fat soy latte?” I laugh every time. I like the line. I like that we can agree that that’s a terrible coffee order. And I like these small moments that can make life in a big city feel a little more intimate. Only this time, he leaves me hanging.

“You’re allowed to have espresso?”

He’s looking at my belly, which, at 7½ months pregnant, is well outside of the “Is she or isn’t she?” arena that tends to make people nervous. Allowed?

I start babbling. “Oh, that’s not really true anymore, the thing about coffee. When you’re this far along, and even earlier too, the studies say it’s …” I trail off, grab my drink, smile apologetically and then kick myself for smiling apologetically.

When you’re pregnant in public, you learn quickly that everyone’s an expert. They’re an expert about what you put in your body–coffee, cabernet, smoked turkey, stinky cheese. They’re an expert about how much weight you ought to gain, and how if you’re not careful, you’ll give yourself diabetes and have to get a C-section. They even have strong feelings about your footwear. It doesn’t matter how old you are, or how well-informed: at 38, I’m of what doctors like to call “advanced maternal age,” and because of my vocation as a health editor and my pastime as a science nerd, I read scientific studies for sport.

But none of that matters. People, well-meaning though they may be, are going to tell you what they think is best, not for you so much, but for your fetus. And even when you know they’re wrong–and trust me, they’re almost always wrong–it won’t matter: you’re going to feel bad about it.

I appreciate that, as a society, we can mostly agree that harming a child is among the worst things you can do. I suspect that that’s part of what undergirds the casual judgment of pregnant women, the same way it undergirds the casual judgment of moms. But that doesn’t make it any less paternalistic, and it doesn’t mean the judgments are based on facts.

Take coffee, which should be anything but controversial in 2017. For decades, the received wisdom was that drinking coffee during pregnancy could contribute to miscarriage risk. Today, according the best, most up-to-date studies–not to be confused with the studies you are most likely to hear about–it’s perfectly safe to have a couple of strong cups per day. But it doesn’t matter that I know that and that my doctor backs me up. As long as my belly pokes out

like it does, I'm going to be offered decaf over espresso and seltzer over wine, and I'm going to get funny looks from strangers when I opt for the latter.

I read somewhere that the rules of pregnancy are meant to prepare women for life as a mother–a life where every choice is one of sacrifice, where putting another's well-being before your own is paramount. That last part I understand, even if it offers a rather retrograde, dim view of motherhood. But it's still based on a false appraisal of risk.

No one wants to fail at being a mother before her first kid even arrives. That's felt especially true for me. Before this pregnancy, I endured multiple miscarriages, followed by months of torturous self-blame. My doctor warned me that the pain wouldn't double with every loss, that it would be logarithmic–the curve getting ever steeper. He also told me that even though there was nothing I could have done to prevent the miscarriages, the guilt may feel unbearable.

He was right. Determined to figure out what I'd done wrong, because surely this must be my fault, I canvassed experts, read studies, scrutinized my diet and had more blood tests than I can count.

Ultimately, I was faced with the evidence–and my best lesson about motherhood so far: that things can go terribly wrong, and there isn't always a why. That those losses, that heartbreak, was, like most heartbreak, completely out of my control. And that this healthy pregnancy, glorious gift that it has been, is too.

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Stories From the Set of Stranger Things, the TV Escape We Need Right Now

Everyone's tired on the set of *Stranger Things*. I'm visiting on a Friday in May, and a months-long, effects-heavy Season 2 shoot is grinding toward its end. "It's going slow," says Millie Bobby Brown, the 13-year-old Emmy nominee who plays the supernatural character Eleven. "Last season, it felt like we were rapid. Everything was fast," she says. But now "the anticipation from the fans scares everyone. It makes the Duffers stressed. It makes us stressed."

The Duffers are Matt and Ross, identical 33-year-old twins and the maestros of a show that was about the only thing every-one seemed able to agree on during the contentious summer of 2016. The Netflix series, whose eight-episode first season arrived with relatively little fanfare that July, was set in 1983 and told the story of a group of young *Dungeons & Dragons*–playing friends who encounter interdimensional forces. As they look for their missing friend Will (Noah Schnapp), they befriend a mysteriously powerful preteen girl (Brown). Will's mother (Winona Ryder) unravels as she searches for him with the help of a hard-living cop (David Harbour). And Will's loner older brother (Charlie Heaton) warily teams up with other teenagers in their small town of Hawkins, Ind., to find him.

But what made the show so addictive was its clever and lovingly detailed packaging, from wood-paneled rec rooms and Schlitz-fueled teen keggers to a soundtrack of Toto and the Clash. References underpinned the story at every level. The show didn't just use Ryder, the queen of 1980s teen cinema, in a comeback role. It also brilliantly employed the visual language of John Hughes and Steven Spielberg as well as the sinister-yet-comforting narratives of Stephen King. *Stranger Things* added up to something that not only felt like it came out of the '80s but also let you relive the decade—even if you weren't there the first time around. All in one bingeable package.

Stranger Things also became a huge hit. While Netflix does not release viewer-ship numbers, the show made an obvious impact. Last Halloween, you might have noticed more than a few kids, and grownups, dressed as Eleven, or wrapped in Christmas lights to look like Ryder's character, Joyce, at her most forlorn. The "*Stranger Things* kids" became fixtures at awards shows, on late-night TV and on magazine covers. Hollywood took notice, too, honoring the show with 18 Emmy nominations and the top prize at the Screen Actors Guild Awards. "To see Meryl Streep standing up and clapping for us was so weird. I never really thought it would happen," says Brown.

If *Stranger Things* now seems like a predestined success, it was a fairly edgy bet even by Netflix standards. After all, the show's creators were as green as they come. The Duffers had fairly thin résumés—a little-seen horror film released in 2015, a writing gig on a short-lived M. Night Shyamalan TV show—when they put together their pitch. It consisted of a book of images and a mock trailer summing up what their show would be. "It was super-nuts," says Matt. "Sometimes I'll ask them point-blank why they let us do it at all." On Oct. 27, when a new season of *Stranger Things* comes out, we'll get to see how nuts exactly—and just how far the Duffers can push television forward by looking backward.

In action, the Duffers tend to move in tandem. When the scene I'm watching them film ends, one brother bolts to advise the actors and the other is up and following before anybody can even parse which one called "Cut." Both wear T-shirts, jeans and the sort of retro sneakers that look like what you might've worn to high school gym class in 1984. Between takes, the kids gleefully goof off. Their acting is jazzy and improvisational as they're encouraged to amp up their terror take after take. The Duffers' parents are visiting the set today, watching the action with headphones on from behind their director sons.

Matt and Ross Duffer grew up in Durham, N.C., where, Matt says, "it was hard to get or even hear about more obscure films." Instead, they went to the video store and rented the sort of crowd-pleasing, all-ages movies that Hollywood doesn't really make anymore. The Duffers claim that their influences are more tonal than specific, that they draw upon the cinema of the past for mood more than detail. "We honestly weren't thinking about the references as much," says Ross. "We'd do a few winks, and of course we talked about *E.T.* when we first came up with this show, but that wasn't the primary focus. Let's just tell the best story we can and hopefully we'll capture some of the magic of these movies we loved growing up."

There's something essential about those references to *Stranger Things*' resonance. They've turned into an Internet parlor game among fans, who hunt out specific shots, for example, that might tie the show to its adventure-film heritage. And despite the Duffers' protestations, it's easy to get them talking about specific sequences that are meant as homage. One scene I observed featured Max (Sadie Sink), a new member of the kid cast this year, driving a car with a block under her foot to reach the gas pedal. "That's exactly like Short Round in *Temple of Doom*," Ross says, referring to Jonathan Ke Quan's character in the second *Indiana Jones* film, which was released the year when *Stranger Things*' second season is set. "Spielberg has an identical shot. The whole scene is informed by something else—and then let's do one wink for the fans." The Duffers are a very specific sort of fan: slightly too young to remember the material they're quoting firsthand. They were too young to see *E.T.* in theaters, for instance, but they were able to watch—and pause, and rewind, and restart—the VHS tape endlessly at home.

The show's first season seemed to wrap up Will's journey out of captivity, only to suggest that he came back more haunted than his buddies might realize. The ending seemed to promise deeper excavation into what the show's characters call "the Upside Down," the nether-world within or beneath Hawkins, with new

kids and a new commitment to figuring out what exactly happened and is still happening in the paranormal town. “This year, in terms of scope and size, it’s much closer to what we’ve always wanted the show to be,” says Matt. The Duffers say this sequel moves the plot forward while keeping the series’ signatures. Among those signatures are, of course, the interplay between the kids—which is running up against a ticking clock of sorts. As Matt puts it, “Our kids are growing, and we have to get the show out, whether it’s a compromise or not.”

Among the biggest expectations for Season 2 is that it come out before the show’s young stars get much older. Working with children plainly has its challenges. “They’re a pain in the ass! I love them, but [by law] you can only work with them for a certain number of hours,” Matt tells me. We’re having a somewhat rushed conversation during a lunch break between shoots for a scene that includes most of the kids. “They’re going to get yanked away from us at 7 even though we’re not going to be done with them,” he adds.

Stranger Things isn’t just about the kids. In the first season, Ryder delivered perhaps her best onscreen work since her Oscar-nominated performance in Martin Scorsese’s 1993 film *The Age of Innocence*. As Joyce, she frantically sought out a son who everybody said was dead but whose presence she could feel bleeding through the walls of her house. Harbour, a Tony-

nominated character actor who had appeared in the *James Bond* franchise, brought soulful fatigue to the role of the alcoholic town police chief, Jim Hopper. Both actors tapped into undercurrents of pain and exhaustion; Ryder was nominated for a Golden Globe, Harbour for an Emmy.

Rolling a cigarette in his set trailer, Harbour calls working with the Duffers the “greatest cinematic creative collaboration I’ve ever had.” The differences between a Broadway-trained thespian and a pair of Blockbuster Video–trained directors has been fruitful for both parties. “I’m much more intellectual and much more academic in my process. I’ll always push for more explanation,” Harbour says. “And they’ll always be like, ‘Well, this is just kind of cool.’ They’re coming at it from an intuitive place. I consider them one being. They share one mind—it’s just twice as big as mine!”

As for working with children, Harbour has had to push himself yet further. “I’ve never had to work with kids before in this capacity. There are pleasures to it, and there are also things that are difficult,” he says. “When something’s good, the relationships that we develop with lead actors, it’s kind of a f-cked-up process. To do that with a 13-year-old child feels tricky. So, like, you know, on the surface, it’s all cute and everybody loves it. But underneath, there’s a real complexity to it.”

Brown came at her role pretty straight, as child actors tend to do. “Eleven is part of me and always will be. I don’t try with her,” she says. “I don’t even know my lines for today’s scene. So it’s like, I don’t know what I’m doing, and that’s what makes it so instinctual.”

Harbour is right about one thing: it *is* really cute, and everybody *does* love it. On set, the kids are both full of capering zest and possessed of that sort of big-kid poise that develops in your early teens. There’s a lot of downtime between takes that adults might spend reading, knitting or staring, bored, into a phone. But the kids

have no trouble keeping busy. Caleb McLaughlin, who plays the cautious Lucas, introduces himself to the Duffers' parents by telling them with some gravity, "I'm fans of you guys as well." Later on, he and Finn Wolfhard, who plays Mike, the heart of his friend group, kill time between takes by singing Bon Jovi into a fan held by castmate Joe Keery. The whirling of the fan's blades distorts the sound so that the words—"Ohhhhhh, we're haaaaalfwaaaaay theeeeere"—come out like an on-the-fritz kitchen appliance. Keery plays Steve, Hawkins' high school stud. At 25 he should know better, and charmingly doesn't, than to encourage them.

They seem like a tribe, in other words. For Wolfhard, who also starred in this year's blockbuster remake of Stephen King's *It*, being on set is an escape from class. "School was difficult for me, elementary school especially," he says. "That was a hard battle. I was getting bullied a lot." For Gaten Matarazzo, finding roles became hard as he got older. He has the disorder known as cleidocranial dysostosis, which affects the bones and teeth. His *Stranger Things* character, Dustin, has it too. Matarazzo casually pops out his front dentures as he tells me, "I still have a lisp, even when I take my teeth out. I was never picked for voice-over or for commercials. I was going out and they said I was good, but I was too short, too toothless." Now Matarazzo is on a show whose entire cast seems, in one way or another, to have found the perfect fit.

That Hollywood is bereft of new ideas these days is hardly a secret: sequels outpace original properties on executives' to-do lists. But what really resonates with viewers isn't just iteration but a sense that the language of the past is being given a new phrasing. *It*, for instance, freshened up a widely known horror story with vivid effects and a slight attitudinal spin while still revering the source material. This year's *Beauty and the Beast* overlaid Gothic glam atop a fresh take on Disney's older tale. Both are among the most successful films in their respective genres ever made. Netflix's successes include revamps of past hits like *Full House*,

One Day at a Time and *Gilmore Girls*. Each updated the story for contemporary audiences while keeping a nostalgic core of friendship and family intact.

Part of what makes *Stranger Things* special is that it has tapped into our culture's fervid need to escape into the past. It subtracted smartphones and helicopter parents and added the sort of mortal peril that any good '80s thriller depends upon. And for all its winks, the show is an irony-free zone. "It's not nasty or mean or condescending or ironic or any of those things," Matt says, "which a lot of content can be right now." He punches the word *content*, a euphemism for art-as-product. "Because there's just so much of that. And there's a lot of shows about protagonists doing really nasty things to other people."

As a result, our own prosaic universe came to feel cinematic. If *Stranger Things* Season 2 is as big or bigger than Season 1, it won't just be because the sets have expanded and the action is more daring. It will be because, more than ever, we want to escape into what's remembered, the pleasures and pains of growing up and the pop culture that accompanied us along the way. The Duffers have found a novel formula that does that by balancing homage and kitsch to create something entirely new.

Plus, the kids, whether you relate to them or to their parents, are on one hell of an adventure. "As we grow up," Wolfhard tells me at

one point on set, “the characters grow up with us. For now, we’ve trademarked them. Until they remake it in 20 years. Or make a spin-off.”

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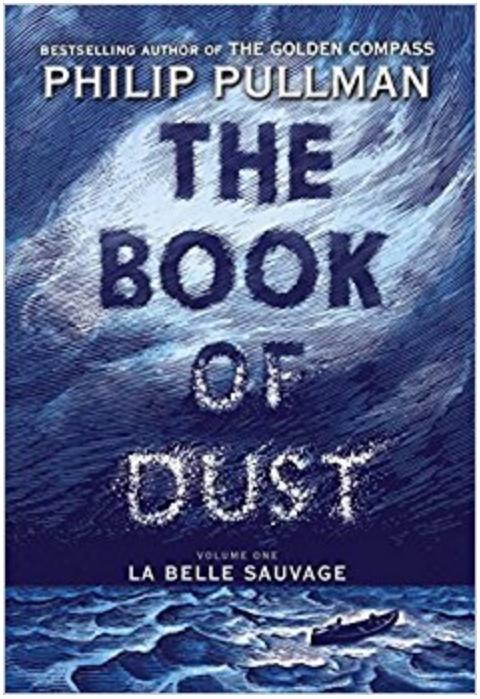
Philip Pullman on His New Trilogy, His Influences and the Upcoming His Dark Materials TV Show



The article contains minor spoilers on the plot of La Belle Sauvage.

It's been over twenty years since Philip Pullman introduced readers to the universe of *His Dark Materials*, and now he's back with the first in a new trilogy entitled *The Book of Dust*.

At the end of the last book in the first trilogy, *The Amber Spyglass*, Pullman's young heroes Lyra and Will have witnessed the death of the heavenly "Authority," unwittingly staged the second fall of Man and cut a hole in the fabric of the underworld to free untold hordes of the dead to become one with the universe. How do you top that?

The answer is, you don't. Instead, in *La Belle Sauvage*, Pullman has shrunk the canvas to present readers with a book that, despite being set over a decade before *His Dark Materials*, is less a prequel

than a companion volume. In it, we meet Malcolm, a curious and lively inkeeper's son who loves nothing more than boating up and down Oxford's canals in the vessel that gives this first volume its name. He soon crosses paths with the infant Lyra, and is thrown into an adventure which takes its cues both from Boy's Own tales of suspense and intrigue, and the fairies and spirits of English folklore.

In a conversation with TIME at his home in Cumnor, Oxfordshire in August, Pullman explained why he'd returned to the universe of *His Dark Materials*, gave some insight into the characters and themes of the new novel, and dropped some hints about what readers can expect from the second volume in the series, to be entitled *The Secret Commonwealth*.

TIME: You've been talking about the possibility of writing a follow-up to *His Dark Materials* for over a decade. Why now?

Philip Pullman: I felt there were more stories to tell. I felt that having established a position vis-a-vis organized religion, I was now free to look at other things that were of interest to me. I wanted to know more about Lyra, I wanted to know about other characters I'd seen peripherally, in the distance, and grew to like.

If *His Dark Materials* was about how innocence turns to experience, what is the theme of this trilogy?

I don't write books to illustrate a theme but I sometimes find a theme developing as I write them. In this one, it's the importance of imaginative vision, in William Blake's terms. The dangers of what he called "single vision" — a narrow, dogmatic point of view that excludes every other angle of vision but what it deems to be true. You see that not just in dogmatic politics and religion, you see it in science, in all kinds of fields. It's always destructive and it's always restrictive and it's always unhelpful. And in this trilogy, that sort of area is going to be what I'm exploring.

But the meaning of a book is never just what the author thinks it is. It's a great mistake to rely on the author to tell you what the meaning is. We don't know. The meaning is only what emerges when the book and the reader meet.

The journey from innocence to experience is still at the heart of this book though, with Malcolm's journey?

Yes, but in a different way. The relationship you have with a six-month-old baby is not a romantic one, but a protective one. And Malcolm is in that relationship with Lyra. He's immensely *seized* by the idea of this baby. He's an only child, he has never even seen a baby before. And he is put in the position of having to protect her. It's a position of great moral responsibility, a great moral weight. And he's capable of bearing it.

Is there an element of autobiography in the writing of Malcolm?

I'd like to think so. I'm not sure I'd be as brave as he is. I suppose Malcolm is to a certain extent the boy I was. But then, Lyra is the girl I was. They're both equally made up characters. I knew Malcolms and I knew Lyras when I was teaching. But yes, there's an element of me in both of them. I loved writing about Malcolm and Alice, who I became very fond of.

Alice, the temperamental teenager who accompanies Malcolm on his quest, seems quite similar to the Lyra of the earlier books.

Well, we'll find out more in the second book about her connection with Lyra, which might be a bit of a surprise. As soon as I thought of Alice, I could see how that was going to develop. Some characters arrive at your desk with either an atmosphere about them, or a sense that there is more to them … an already developed hinterland or where they're going. Mrs Coulter, for example. As

soon as I thought of her I thought, yes there she is. Alice was the same.

Did the character of Malcolm spring fully formed too?

Yes. I saw him with his canoe, and he just looked up. I used to be a teacher, for about 12 years, and I was teaching children of his age and Lyra's age as she was in *His Dark Materials* and I knew lots of children like that. Immensely interesting, immensely likable and immensely unpredictable. A curious mixture at that age of complete innocence and the beginnings of intellectual maturity and discovery. It's an extraordinary age.

This novel is set entirely in England, and mostly in Oxfordshire. What is it about Oxford that keeps bringing you back?

It's a very rich place to write about. There are all kinds of things to write about. There are so many Oxfords and so many atmospheres. You could never get tired of it. Besides, it's just down the road. I don't have to go to Heathrow and get on a plane and deal with passports in order to research it.

Do you need to travel a lot to research the places you go to in your novels, like the Arctic?

No, because I make my world up. What I don't know, I'll find out in some way or another. And what I can't find out, I'll make up. The function of research for a novelist is simply to give you enough *stuff* so that you can make up something that you need. My test for it is, if I were reading this, would I think it's genuine? If it looks alright to me, as an average reader, who has read a bit about the subject, I reckon that'll do.

What about interviews?

No, because people don’t tell me things. It’s not in my nature. I can spend time with someone most agreeably, but they would never tell me anything important about themselves. I haven’t got that receptive, engaging, welcoming air about me. It’s a great gift, but not something that could be faked. I could have made myself interested in people … but it’s a question of whether people feel at ease about you or not, and I don’t have that capacity.

Evidently, that hasn’t impeded your creative spark.

Perhaps it encourages it.

In the new book, you delve into what life is like under the Magisterium, the “theocracy” that rules Britain. I wonder if there were parallels to what you see in the world today that were of particular influence?

Yes, of course. We see in the Middle East and in isolated pockets of western Europe the enormous enthusiasm which that point of view is accepted. Especially by young men who love the idea of an absolute answer to everything, for which they’re willing to die, and to kill. That’s the absolute final pitch of single vision. What the prophet says is what is true, and everything else is false. That cast of mind has not very often acquired political power, but when it does it’s absolutely murderous.

In many ways it seems as much like Soviet Russia, as historical theocracies like the Spanish Inquisition.

Well, Soviet Russia was, in all respects except one, a theocracy. When I was accused of promoting atheism and doing down the church and so on, I used to make this point. The Soviet regime had a holy book, by Marx. It had a priesthood, the Communist Party. It had even holy relics, the corpses of Lenin and Stalin in Red Square. It had a whole system of secret denunciation, just as they did in Venice under the Spanish Inquisition. And this is very important:

they had a teleological world view. The church was doing all this because it was helping re-establish Christ's rule. In Soviet Russia, they were working towards the dictatorship of the proletariat. The parallels are extraordinary and multiple. It was in effect a theocracy. The fact they were atheist made no difference at all. So, my antipathy to organized religion is an antipathy to theocracy and an antipathy to people who think they have the answer getting their hands on the levers of power.

The book changes direction in the second half, as a huge and mysterious flood rises. What inspired that?

Well, the flood is a kind of metaphor of course. Floods are things that carry you away. Floods are also things that uncover and bring to the surface things that have been hidden, and so on. So all those things are involved. But one of the origins of this story, I'm certain, was from my childhood in Australia. In 1956, the River Murray flooded in Victoria and also South Australia. We were living in Adelaide, as my stepfather was in the RAF. This flood came along, and I remember driving out to somewhere in the country from where we could see the flood. It was astonishing. It was a mass, immense, as wide as the sea, of grey water, whipped up by a cold wind, flowing inexorably from there to there. The *power* of it. It was an impression that never left me. And I always wanted to write about a flood. So I made my own flood here in Oxfordshire. And of course it's a metaphor. It's more than a flood. It's a sweeping away of all sorts of things.

Up to that point the novel has been quite realistic, but the flood brings us into the fantasy world that one of the Gyptians in the novel calls "The Secret Commonwealth." What is that?

Robert Kirk wrote this book in the 1680s, it's his term for the world of fairies, gnomes, sprites … the world of spirits basically. Which, for him, as a clergyman was very real. He was also writing from the point of view of a culture in Scotland and in Ireland where the

spirit world is very real. I'm fascinated by that world, which is the complete opposite of the world that science tells us about. This is not in any sense an anti-science thing, but in William Blake's terms I'm a proponent of two-fold, three-fold and four-fold vision and not single vision.

Some writers about science use sentences like x equals nothing but y. Love is nothing more than the excitation of neurons in the brain, something like that. I would much rather say, love is the excitation of neurons in the brain, *among other things*. And I think that would be Blake's attitude as well. That it can be all of those things. And that we're not truly seeing it unless we see all of those things. That's a lesson which Lyra and Malcolm will have to learn.

The first book of the original trilogy told a complete story, somewhat. At the end of this book, there are many things left unresolved and explained.

That was a different kind of book, with a more straightforward story. Lyra has lost something, [her friend] Roger has disappeared, she's determined to find him. This is a different kind of mystery, a different kind of story. Various things are set in train in this book which will develop in the next one and the third.

If things are unexplained, it's because I haven't explained them to myself. There are things that it would be impolite to enquire into. For example, people have occasionally asked me how daemons are born. I've never sought to go into the gynecology of daemons and I think it would be rather impolite. People can imagine that for themselves.

What can you tell us about the rest of the trilogy?

In the next book, which is going to be called *The Secret Commonwealth*, we are fully in the realms of experience. It will be 20 years later, Lyra is going to be an undergraduate and her own

woman. And completely unlike in this one, and completely unlike the Lyra of *His Dark Materials*, she's going to have the beginnings of an adult's preoccupations. There will be a lot of trouble.

The earlier trilogy was released at a time when social conservatism was in the ascendance, which I think feeds into the absolutism that you're talking about. Do you feel like that has changed now in the U.S.?

What we were seeing then was the influence of the evangelical Republicanism on the Republican Party in particular. They sold their soul to this side of influence and effectively could do nothing to prevent Donald Trump when he came along. Because he seemed to be saying the things they wanted to hear, about cutting taxes and preventing immigration and all these things… but they didn't see what an unguided missile he was going to be.

Back then, you were accused of peddling "atheism for kids." Do you expect more controversy from this book?

No, this is a different kind of book.

Do you still receive letters from people telling you you're going to hell?

No … yet I haven't gone away. Clearly, no evident evil has sprouted from [the books'] presence in the world for 20 years. There's nothing they can point to and say this man ought to be burned at the stake.

It feels like that religious absolutism has, to some extent, filtered into politics.

Yes, you can see it in Brexit. Once we throw off the chains of Europe, we can pay 350 million pounds a week to the National Health Service! Absolute bullsh-t of course. But they can say it,

because they know the answer. Or because they pretend to know the answer.

Do you think the storyteller has a responsibility to reflect that in their writing?

It's something I've thought quite a lot about. We are citizens too. So we have an obligation to do as citizens should do, which is to be honest where we can. To denounce tyranny and lies where we can. We have those responsibilities which are borne by everyone. So yeah, we do have that sort of responsibility. We have other responsibilities as well, of providing for the family. Of looking after the language — which is our tool, our medium. Our overriding responsibility is our responsibility to the story.

Is there also a responsibility to breed curiosity? It feels like an absence of curiosity is what makes you susceptible to demagoguery.

Absolutely. Curiosity is a virtue. The traditional Christian virtues of temperance, justice, fortitude, I agree with all of them. I've nothing to disagree with on Christian virtues except one, which is faith. I would rather substitute curiosity. Intellectual curiosity is one of the strongest virtues we have.

***His Dark Materials* is going to be a television show, on the BBC. You seem to have a mixed track record when it comes to adaptations.**

I've been through all sorts of adaptations, some of them more successful than others. It's been a radio play. It's been a theatrical play, at the National Theater. It's been a Hollywood movie. It's had all kinds of embodiments.

The thing about a movie is that you've got to distill 12-13 hours of story into 120 minutes, and of course you can't do it because you

have to leave things out. Even a very faithful adaptation like *Lord of the Rings* left an enormous lot out, because you have to. The great advantage of the new world of long form television is that you can put much more in. So you can allow the time for a story to develop. So I'm hoping that will be the case for this adaptation.

Are you hoping for something along the lines of *Game of Thrones*?

I haven't watched it. Not really my sort of thing. I don't watch or read very much fantasy. I never really have. I read *Lord of the Rings* when I was an undergraduate, but I was very callow and easily impressed. Far less impressed by it now.

Martin famously struggles with finishing his work. Was the process of writing this burdensome? I know you declined to cut your hair until you were finished…

It was superstition. I made a stupid promise to myself, or a bargain with the muse or something. If I don't cut my hair, this book will be all right won't it? So I grew my ponytail which I still have in a drawer somewhere, in a Ziploc bag. I'm going to give it to the Bodleian Library. That was my personal superstition. I don't know if it makes a difference or not.

This transcript has been edited for length and clarity

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John Green on Mental Illness and Writing a Book That Mirrors His Own Life

Megan McCluskey is a staff writer at TIME. She covers culture, focusing on horror, fantasy, and science fiction.

Turtles All the Way Down is the first novel from YA fan-favorite John Green since the release of his 2012 phenomenon *The Fault in Our Stars*. The book tells the story of Aza Holmes, a 16-year-old girl living in Indianapolis who attempts to solve the mystery of a fugitive billionaire while grappling with severe anxiety and obsessive-compulsive disorder.

TIME recently spoke with Green about the novel and how it explores the way mental illness can affect daily life. The 40-year-old author has previously laid bare his own struggles with mental health, a topic that he thinks should be discussed openly.

TIME: How did you want to depict Indianapolis, where you were born and now live?

John Green: My wife Sarah and I have lived there for 10 years now and I love it. I wanted to write about it the way that I think most teenagers relate to their hometowns — they have a certain fondness for the place they're from, but they see with great clarity what's wrong with the place that they're from too.

Where did this story come from? How did you come up with the idea to have a fugitive billionaire propel the action?

I wanted to write a detective story about a detective whose brain disorder is unhelpful. Because there's so many detective stories about obsessive people who are brilliant detectives because of their obsessiveness and my experience with obsessiveness has been more or less the complete opposite. I wanted to write a detective

story where the plot keeps getting interrupted by this person's inability to live in the world in the way that she wants to. And then I needed some big, somewhat fantastical mystery. I also wanted to write about the ways that different kinds of privilege intersect in people's lives and the ways that they blind you.

You've been extremely open about talking about your own struggles with mental illness. What was it like to write about the specific type of OCD and anxiety you've suffered from?

I had to write with enough distance from myself to make it OK, to make it feel safe. And so Aza has somewhat different focai of her obsessive concerns and the behaviors she uses to manage them. I still can't really talk directly about my own obsessions. The word triggering has become so broadly used in popular culture, but anyone who has experienced an anxiety attack knows how badly they want to avoid it. It was really hard, especially at first, to write about this thing that's been such a big part of my life. But in another way, it was really empowering because I felt like if I could give it form or expression I could look at it and I could talk about it directly rather than being scared of it. And one of the main things I wanted to do in the book was to get at how isolating it can be to live with mental illness and also how difficult it can be for the people who are around you because you're so isolated.

You emphasize the idea that there's no magical cure for mental illness throughout the book. Why was it important to you to convey that message?

We really like stories that involve conquering obstacles and involve victory over adversity. And I love those stories too. It's just that hasn't been my story with mental illness and I didn't really want it to be Aza's. For me, it's not something I expect to defeat in my life. It's not like a battle I expect to win. It's something I expect to live with and still have a fulfilling life.

What inspired you to use the turtles all the way down story — an anecdote that illustrates the problem with infinite regression — as a metaphor for Aza's struggle?

I love that story. When I first heard it I was a college student. I thought that it was about how stupid superstition is and how science is right and everyone else is wrong. And now I realize — or I think now — that that's not the point of the story at all. The point of the story is that the scientist is right but the old woman saying that the world rests on a turtles all the way down situation, she's also right. They're both right because obviously the world is a sphere — I'm not like a flat-Earther or anything —but the world is also the stories we tell about it. The stories we tell about it matter. They shape the actual world and they shape our actual lives. So that is very helpful to me in thinking about why I like writing and reading. But it also is very helpful to me in reminding me that I do have some say in framing my own experience. Even though I may go for long periods of time where I don't have control over my thoughts and that is scary and destabilizing for my sense of self, I do have some say in the story of my life.

Your books are read by people of all ages. But what do you feel is the importance of incorporating issues such as mental illness into books for young adults?

I think there have been lots of good YA books about mental illness over the years. For me, one of the reasons I like writing YA books is because I love sharing a shelf with the other YA books that are being published now. I just think it's a really wonderful time in young adult literature. I also like writing about teenagers because they're doing stuff for the first time and it's really intense. And one of the things they're doing for the first time is asking the big questions about suffering and meaning and whether meaning is inherent in human life or it's something we have to construct.

How do you feel this book fits into the current conversation about mental health and the push by many to destigmatize it?

I think some progress has been made in destigmatizing mental illness. I think there's still a lot of stigma in the workplace. I think unfortunately there's still a lot of stigma around hiring. I'm not a psychologist, I'm definitely not an expert on this stuff but one of the problems with the stigmatization is that it compounds the isolation. And I really hope we can keep breaking that down because I remember how alone I felt in it in high school and it was a big part of what made it so difficult to bear.

This is the second book in a row you've written from a female perspective. What do you find challenging about writing characters that you don't directly identify with?

Well it's always challenging. Any character is a sort of jump in empathy. Any time you're writing from the perspective of a fictional character, you're imagining what it's like to be not you. And that's one of the things I love about writing fiction is that it feels like an escape from my brain which can sometimes feel like not that fun of a place to hang out. I hope [Aza] seems real to people.

And you also had this great female friendship between Aza and Daisy in this one.

Yeah I really wanted to write about friendship. I wanted to write about all the different kinds of love that can sustain and support you. Romantic love is the one that we focus on the most in our cultural conversation and it's certainly very important for a lot of people. But for a lot of people, other kinds of love are the most important. When I was in high school, it was the love of my friends that got me through.

***Turtles All the Way Down* is your first book since the massive success of *The Fault in Our Stars*. Can you talk about your experience writing the follow-up to that?**

As long as I felt like I was writing the follow-up to that, I wasn't writing. It was an incredible experience and an incredible privilege to have so many people respond to that book so kindly. It meant a lot to me but it did also mean that when I started trying to write again, I felt like there were people watching over my shoulder and that made it impossible for a long time. I think it was impossible for a variety of reasons. I also think I just had a period of bad mental health, which happens sometimes. Honestly, I felt like maybe I wouldn't write another book and I got to be OK with that.

Can you tell me a little bit about fitting so many literary references into your work? What's the process there?

In this story they came along the way or in some cases earlier. Some of the stuff was scavenged for parts from previous failed attempts at writing a book. But like that line in *Ulysses* where Molly Bloom says, "O Jamesy let me up out of this," that's something that I have said in my own life to whoever I feel like is forcing me to think these intrusive thoughts. That's something that I've said thousands of times in my head or out loud.

Are there any YA authors right now that you'd like to highlight as deserving of more attention?

Angie Thomas's book *The Hate U Give* is getting a lot of attention, but it should get more. It should be a book that's being read, I think, in every high school English class in the country. It's such a special book. I think it's going to be remembered the way we talk now about *The Outsiders*. There's also a book called *Piecing Me Together* by Renee Watson that is a brilliant look at the role that art plays in the lives of young people, but also all of these different ways that race and gender and privilege intersect in the life of this

one really extraordinary young woman. That book I have been thinking about nonstop for the last six months.

What's on your radar? What are you reading right now?

I just finished *Little Fires Everywhere* by Celeste Ng which is amazing. It's so good. You'll read like the first six pages and you'll be like this is going to be the best. And it's that good all the way through.

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Wonderstruck Is a Tender and Vital Piece of Filmmaking

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

Todd Haynes makes films that are tender and vital, with a deep affection for the past that’s never just misplaced nostalgia. He knows it’s a place where real people lived, loved and sometimes suffered. Haynes’ extraordinary new film, *Wonderstruck*, builds on everything he has done before, but it’s also a crazy leap, a picture that works almost against all odds. Based on a novel by Brian Selznick, who also wrote the screenplay, it tells the dovetailing stories of two 12-year-olds, Ben (Oakes Fegley) and Rose (Millicent Simmonds), living 50 years apart. Ben, growing up in 1977 Gunflint, Minn., has just lost his mother (Michelle Williams) and has always wondered about the father he never knew. His mother refused to answer his questions, and he’s haunted by a recurring nightmare in which he’s pursued by wolves, a sign that his mind is working overtime to make sense of his grief.

Then a freak accident causes Ben to lose his hearing. It also sparks a journey to New York City, in all its perilous ’70s glory, where he makes a new friend, Jaden Michael’s Jamie. He also finds a connection with a girl who, 50 years earlier, felt just as lost. Rose, also deaf, lives in Hoboken, N.J., with her father, a distracted man who can’t be bothered to try to understand her. At one point he tosses her a book on lip-reading, barking orders for her to study it.

It’s filled with tiny print and macabre line drawings, and it terrifies her. She tears a page out and folds it into the shape of a small tower, which she adds to a little fantasy city she’s made entirely out of paper.

Rose also finds solace at the movies. She idolizes the silent-film actor Lillian Mayhew (a luminous Julianne Moore), and in one of *Wonderstruck*‘s most astonishing scenes, she gazes at the image of this resplendent, expressive creature who speaks a language of silence she fully understands. On the silent screen, Mayhew, who appears to be modeled on Lillian Gish, speaks in an alphabet of broad physical gestures and eyes that reflect anguish or joy like light from a prism. Rose watches, rapt. She learns that Mayhew will be performing onstage in New York City and so she, like Ben, runs toward it.

This is an intricate, high-reaching piece of film-making, and there are places where the mechanics don’t run as smoothly as they should. But the film’s beauty runs so deep, it doesn’t matter. *Wonderstruck* embraces so many shimmery, evanescent ideas, it’s a marvel that any picture–let alone one you can take your kids to–can hold them. This is a romance of New York City, a love letter to the pleasure of making something by hand, a story of finding the place where you belong and of finding your way to the people who understand you.

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Love Rises Above Politics in Beats Per Minute

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

Movies about political activists tend to put the politics first and the human second. Not so with French writer-director Robin Campillo's *BPM* (Beats Per Minute). Set in early-1990s Paris, the film follows a group of ACT UP members as they launch AIDS-awareness demonstrations, squabble during meetings and let off steam on the dance floor, all in the service of keeping themselves, and anyone else at risk, alive.

Campillo, who co-wrote the script with AIDS activist and educator Philippe Mangeot, captures the mood of an era with a specificity that's by turns somber and joyous. The love story between guarded HIV-negative activist Nathan (Arnaud Valois) and the more politically aggressive–and HIV-positive–Sean (Nahuel Pérez Biscayart) is the story's strongest magnet. A tender and captivating sex scene between the two suggests that falling in love requires more than just the engagement of mind, heart and body: each

partner also brings baggage. But the total burden is lighter when two people shoulder it together. This is how you love when your life depends on it.

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Colin Farrell Finds Darkness in The Killing of a Sacred Deer

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

Greek filmmaker Yorgos Lanthimos' style, a kind of deadpan harangue, is ideally something you either love or hate. To be in the middle, to merely respect it, is the harder position. And Lanthimos' predilection for inflicting cruelty on his characters spills over in his latest, *The Killing of a Sacred Deer*.

Colin Farrell plays Steven Murphy, a sure-of-himself heart surgeon and the head of a numbingly placid American family. He regularly engages in clinical sex with his wife Anna (Nicole Kidman), an ophthalmologist. His two children, teenager Kim (Raffey Cassidy) and preadolescent Bob (Sunny Suljic), seem blandly normal in every way. But Steven has been secretly meeting with Martin (Barry Keoghan, seen recently in *Dunkirk*), a mysterious youth with eyes as blank as steel. Steven is affluent and closed off to almost everything most other humans need to worry about. Martin

has next to nothing. Yet the boy has a strange power over Steven, and it becomes clear that he's trying to exact some sort of punishment.

It's not that *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* isn't brainy or ambitious. Dense with layers of biblical lore and Greek tragedy, it's like a cake that's impressively tall but also unpalatably dry. It's an art-house special-ops mission, tiresomely clinical in its sadism. It leaves you feeling like you've been lectured to, as if Lanthimos decided that we don't already know what a vile place the world can be and thus need to be taken by the hand and shown–but with style. Ignore Lanthimos at your peril or at your discretion. You might respect him, but you don't have to love him.

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Nathan For You’s Oddball Humor Hides a Serious Message

I’m one of the many viewers who, at the height of the *Modern Family* era, wanted TV comedy to get more class conscious–to develop characters who worried, or at least cared, about money. It’s fitting that Comedy Central’s M.B.A. fantasia *Nathan for You*, in its fourth season, fulfilled that wish in a twisted, monkey’s-paw manner. The show has made steady business of taking good intentions too far.

Host Nathan Fielder, a Canadian comedian, asks small-business owners what it would take to make their operation a success, and then oversteps in trying to hack a solution. (The situations and reactions, startlingly, are real.) He has the zealous, misguided confidence that it takes to attempt to compete in a post–financial collapse economy.

Fielder’s character (also named Nathan Fielder) meets with owners of nail salons and travel agencies in the less-photogenic parts of California and “helps” them carry out imaginative yet thuddingly literal ideas. A restaurant that was denied a license to sell food at a hockey game bypasses the rules with a sealed plastic suit that Fielder fills with hot chili and wears under his clothes. Concerned

about the rapaciousness of Uber, Fielder attempts to set up a sleeper cell within the company, drivers who will turn passengers against the car service with bad odors and the song “Mambo No. 5.” (In a twist, the driver Fielder tries to help ends up joining Uber–there’s no better way to make money today.)

Fielder’s methods are ludicrous. But the point he makes is sharp: bizarre grasps, inflected with Silicon Valley loopiness and P.T. Barnum hucksterism, are the last resort of people who have been told that entrepreneurialism is the last virtue. The show is a dark, worthy companion piece to ABC’s relentlessly sunny *Shark Tank*, on which inventors smile their way through interrogation before being tossed a small slice of capital. Unflappable and earnest, Fielder convinces you of his certainty that any business can succeed. Compared with its idealistic lead, the show itself is wiser, more engaged and less sure.

Nathan for You *airs on Comedy Central Thursdays at 10 p.m. E.T.*

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Too Funny to Fail: TV That Was Too Funny for Its Time

When he left *Saturday Night Live* in 1993, Dana Carvey was at the top of the entertainment industry. His new sketch-comedy show on ABC would be bolstered by rising talents like Louis CK, Stephen Colbert and Steve Carell. What could go wrong?

Everything, obviously. Hulu's new documentary *Too Funny to Fail* examines the almost instantaneous collapse of *The Dana Carvey Show*, a would-be smash that began with Carvey impersonating President Bill Clinton … while breastfeeding puppies. Carvey wanted to move past conventional comedy to edgier, more surreal stuff, even though, as Colbert tells the audience, "all people wanted to see was Dana Carvey doing an impression of Bill Clinton!" Carvey's show was both an incubator of talent and a precursor to what would come later. Today its absurdism would fit right in online. *Too Funny to Fail* is a fascinating story of just how much risk Hollywood was willing to accept back then.

Too Funny to Fail *is now streaming on Hulu*

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Q&A: Masha Gessen Sees a Bleak Future for Putin's Russia

Simon Shuster is a senior correspondent at TIME. He covers international affairs, with a focus on Russia and Ukraine. For his first book, *The Showman*, he reported inside the Ukrainian President's compound in Kyiv as the Russian invasion unfolded.

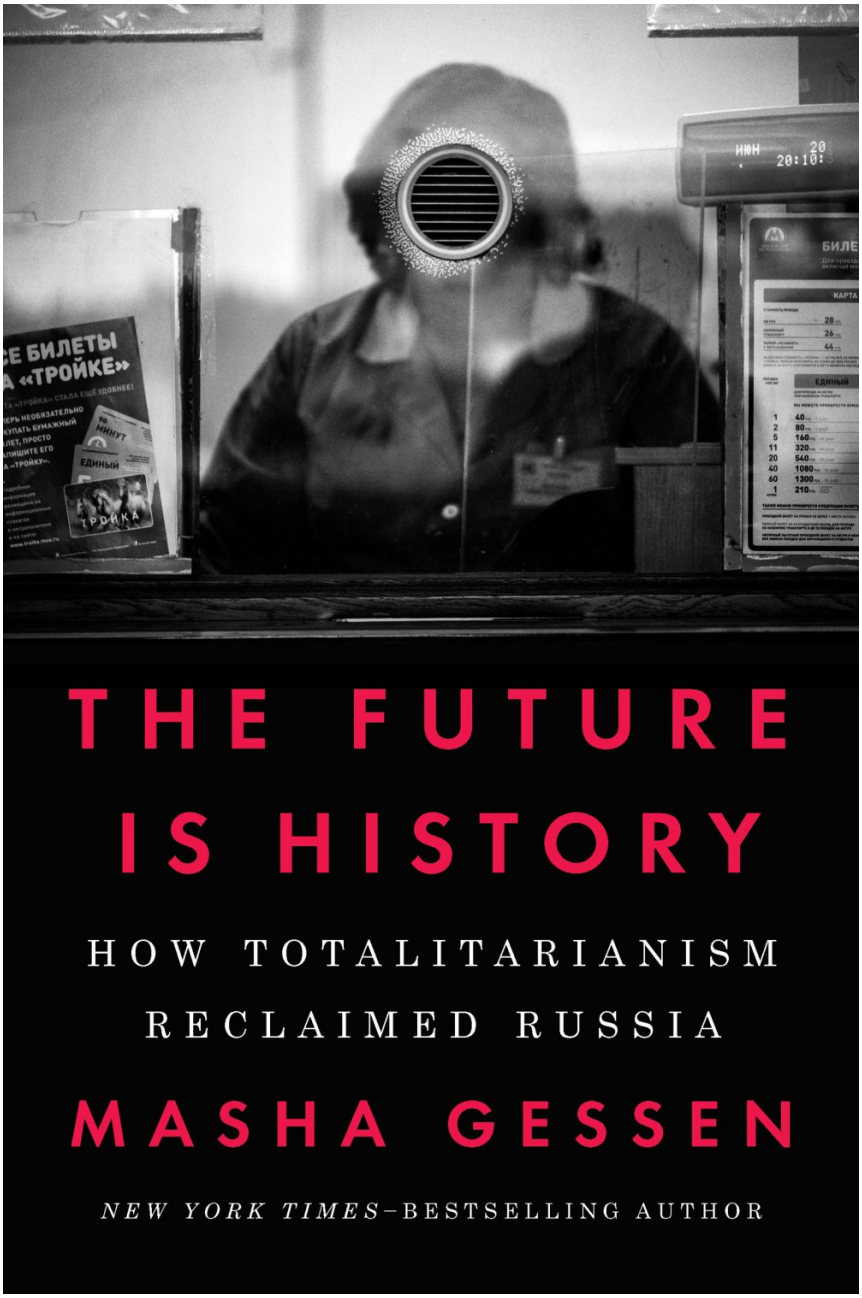
Following her 2012 biography of Russian President Vladimir Putin, the author and journalist Masha Gessen turns her focus to the social traumas and disappointed hopes of her native country, as seen through the perspectives of the seven characters in her latest non-fiction book, *The Future is History: How Totalitarianism Reclaimed Russia*, which was published on Oct. 3.

Three of the book's characters – a psychoanalyst, a sociologist and a nationalist philosopher – possess what Gessen calls the "tools of knowing" that are required to analyze Russia's transition from Soviet communism to Putin's brand of state capitalism. The other

four are young people, born during the final years of the Soviet empire, who feel the lingering effects of its dissolution on their own skin: one through the murder of her father, another through her struggle with Russia's system of political repression.

Gessen spoke to TIME on Sept. 26 about the roots and faults of the system Putin built – and its similarities to President Donald Trump's America. Below is a transcript of the conversation, shortened and edited for clarity.

TIME: One of the Russian phrases at the center of your book is *budushchevo net* – "There is no future." What does that mean to you and to the characters in the book?



GESSEN: I started out trying to tell a story of Russia's trauma. And one of the hallmarks of trauma is the loss of the ability to plan for the future. It's really about the loss of control. This sense of having no control over your own life is very important to creating a totalitarian subject. People express that with the phrase *budushchevo net*.

The word "totalitarian" is usually reserved for the most repressive regimes, like North Korea or Hitler's Germany. Why do you believe Russia has reached that level of state control?

I’m not using that word in relation to Putin. The regime that exists in Russia is not a totalitarian regime. Putin has created the regime of a mafia state. But because he created this regime on the ruins of a totalitarian society, totalitarian habits have kicked in. It’s a bizarre situation, where the regime sends out signals that aren’t about establishing totalitarian control. The regime just wants to plunder and stay in power. But society, which has been conditioned by so many years of totalitarianism, responds by creating totalitarian mechanisms, [like] when people start raiding bookstores in their own neighborhoods to make sure there is de facto censorship.

So Russian totalitarianism comes from the grassroots, not from the top down?

What we have is neither of those things. The Kremlin just sends out signals that are actually not that different from Trump’s dog whistling to his supporters, to the people who share his idea of this imaginary past. Trump did this after the violence in Charlottesville and after the athletes began kneeling during the national anthem. He sends out these signals to his supporters. And in America the response comes from both sides of the debate, often with people showing solidarity with each other, like the athletes taking a knee.

But Russian society responds to such signals in a very different way. In Russia the dog whistle does not elicit cries of protest. Because of its history with totalitarianism, Russian society responds with mobilization.

What are they mobilizing towards?

Scholars of totalitarianism talk about the importance of this constant movement, this forever war, this need to do battle on behalf of something that needs protection. In Russia, this something has been postulated as faith and traditional values.

At least one of the characters in your book also mobilized against Putin during the protests in 2011 and 2012. How important is this form of political awakening in Russia today?

I'm pessimistic about such political awakenings. For most people these awakenings are very short-lived. As the protests died down in 2012, there was no contradiction for them in returning to their regular lives and finding nothing about the regime objectionable.

What about this year's wave of anti-Putin protests? They were widely attended by Russian teenagers who were born and raised during Putin's 18 years in power.

Yes, and there was an incredible intellectual and emotional focus on the teenagers who were protesting. But that's indicative to me of a really sad tendency. After the Soviet Union collapsed, people thought the last Soviet generation was going to be the great hope for democracy. When that failed, their hopes shifted to the first post-Soviet generation, and then the second one. And now the people who were the young vanguard of the protests just five years ago, they have already written themselves off, and they are looking to teenagers to save the country. And what if they don't?

But Russian teenagers did not experience the traumas of the Soviet collapse. So aren't they more immune to these traumas, these totalitarian tendencies you describe?

That's a philosophical question. There's the hypothesis that things just keep happening to Russians, things that keep turning them into the same kind of subjects, as opposed to citizens. The more credible hypothesis, I think, is that there is a kind of trauma, a social trauma that is passed on from generation to generation. And that doesn't go away just because we all decided that the Soviet regime is no more.

After the U.S. elections, Putin has often been depicted in the West as some all-power figure. Do you think the West overestimates him?

It depends. I think his power in influencing the U.S. elections is overestimated, because there is an overwhelming desire to lay blame for Trump somewhere outside the United States. But otherwise I don't think it's overestimated. … He does wield unilateral power in his country. Is there a system of checks and balances that would limit his power? There isn't.

But does he have the kind of absolute control usually associated with totalitarian regimes?

Do people in Russia today live as people in the Soviet Union lived under Stalin? Of course not. But does [Putin] have the same political staying power as Stalin did? Does he have the near guarantee of maintaining power and being able to do whatever he wants for the rest of his life? Yes.

Will his authoritarian system survive after he's gone?

When Stalin died, the Eisenhower Administration was terrified about what would happen. They feared that the hardliners would come to power. Which is incredible to think about. What was their concept of a hardliner if the baseline was Josef Stalin? This suggests that the devil you know has incredible symbolic power in politics. … The idea that hardliners might come to power if Putin disappears is very useful to him. It's something that every dictator cultivates, this idea that there is someone even scarier.

So what future do you see for Russia after Putin?

I don't have a lot of hope for Russia when Putin goes, because I think that the kind of damage that has been done to that country hasn't been understood. We've never seen a country that has been

this battered. And I don't know whether there is any way for it to recover. When Putin goes, I think Russia is not going to stay within its current borders. There is going to be some kind of redrawing of the federation. And if there is any hope, then it's for the countries that are formed in the wake of the Russian Federation that manage to narratively divorce themselves from Russian history.

You're saying the country will break apart. Doesn't that play into Putin's propaganda that without him there is no Russia?

Russia continues to be an empire in a world that has pretty effectively dispensed with empires. So why is the Russian Federation of more than 80 constituent parts, most of which have distinct national identities, some of which have distinct languages and cultures, and all of which now, as a result of being plundered by the Putin regime, have nationalist movements – why should they stay together?

So Putin's personal hold on power is all that's holding Russia together?

Since Putin does not think he is going to die, there is not going to be any succession plan in place when he dies. And there is going to be a period of disarray and uncertainty. And that will be a perfect opening for the final break-up of the empire.

That sounds like a terrifying prospect.

I hope we live long enough to see it.

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